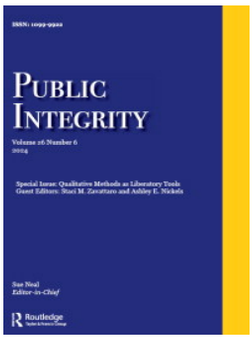

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Learning from the Literature: Fundraising Communication and Ethics

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ABSTRACT
Communication is critical for nonprofit fundraising activity because it fosters trust and accountability as well as enhances mutual understanding of the nonprofit's mission and objectives. Nonprofit organizations develop their own strategies based on who they communicate with and utilize a variety of content through various channels and media. Although it is critical for nonprofits to use their funds efficiently for communication and fundraising, they must also consider ethical concerns. Utilizing a text network analysis and narrative review, we find that although research on fundraising communication has been increasing in the past years, ethical fundraising communication has been rarely studied. Furthermore, beneficiaries and fundraisers have been far less studied compared to donors. The results also show that the emergence of new media such as social media was the main driver of diversifying research in recent years. Our findings suggest that nonprofits are ethically and equally accountable to both givers (donors and funders) and receivers (beneficiaries and recipients). Especially, it is critical being cautious when dealing with socially vulnerable populations such as the elderly, patients, and those in need. This study provides directions for future research and practical implications.

KEYWORDS
Fundraising; communication; ethics

Due to increasingly competitive environments of fundraising, nonprofit professionals often fall in ethical dilemmas. For example, ethical intentions and motivations (virtue ethics) of philanthropic practices do not always produce best outcomes for those in need (consequentialism) (Levy, 2002; Ostrander, 2007). In an effort to promote ethical standards, professional associations, such as the Association of Fundraising Professionals (AFP) and the Independent Sector, have developed and adopted ethical principles (Association of Fundraising Professionals [AFP], 2019; Independent Sector, 2015; Rohrbach, 2013). Such ethical principles generally include some languages of legal compliance and professional codes of ethics (Hansen, 2022; MacQuillin & Sargeant, 2019; Rohrbach, 2013). A code of ethics is a set of aspirations, rules, and/or guidelines representing the values of the group or profession to which it applies (Grobman, 2007). For instance, the Independent Sector's principle 29 states that "[a] charitable organization must provide donors with specific acknowledgments of charitable contributions, in accordance with IRS requirements, as well as information to facilitate the donors' compliance with tax law requirements" (Independent Sector, 2015, p. 40). A code of ethics is useful for raising awareness of the ethical dimensions of decision making and assisting practitioners in navigating the complexities of decision making.

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While research on fundraising has grown significantly since the 1980s, scholars have primarily focused on the characteristics of donors and giving motivations (Bekkers & Wiepking, 2011; Bhati & Hansen, 2020; Lindahl & Conley, 2002). Bekkers and Wiepking (2011) reviewed scholarly articles and categorized charitable giving into eight mechanisms: awareness of need, solicitation, costs and benefits, altruism, reputation, psychological benefits, values, and efficacy. Despite not being directly addressed in the study, each mechanism involves a series of communications among fundraisers, donors, and beneficiaries, not to mention solicitation. As communication is essential for fundraising activity, nonprofit organizations develop their own strategies for fundraising communication and utilize a variety of messages and media. Ethical fundraising communication considers ethical matters in the practice of fundraising when communicating with or about nonprofit stakeholders. Given that communication is imperative for fundraising, ethical communication is the *raison d'être* of ethical fundraising and, thus, central to the success and sustainability of nonprofit organizations. This is particularly so because ethical fundraising communications help nonprofits to build trust by promoting a good and professional reputation which is the backbone of these organizations. For these reasons, ethical principles mentioned above also contain fundraising communications (e.g., the Independent Sector's principle 27 and the AFP's Standards of fundraising practice).

Such ethics of fundraising, however, have received scant consideration from scholars and tend to heavily focus on donors (MacQuillin & Sargeant, 2019). Bhati and Hansen (2020) analyzed experimental research articles on fundraising between 2007 and 2019 and found that these studies largely ignore ethical issues associated with beneficiaries and fundraisers. Furthermore, although their analysis was limited to experimental research articles, Bhati and Hansen (2020) pointed out that scholars should pay more attention to topics of ethics in the study of fundraising. More recently, Jung, Kim, and Suh (2022) reviewed marketing research in the nonprofit sector from 2000 to 2019 and found that the keyword "ethics" appears only between 2015 and 2019. Lastly, the Independent Sector's Principles from 27 to 33 under Section 4 (Responsible Fundraising) do not encompass any reference to the beneficiaries or clients of a nonprofit organization (Independent Sector, 2015).

Before setting up our research questions, we initially searched for journal articles that primarily consider ethics in fundraising. The results of this preliminary search yielded unexpected findings. When we searched for articles using one keyword, "fundraising," the search result showed over 2,500 journal articles, but the number was dramatically reduced to 96 when we added "ethic*" in the search condition. This initial search shows that there is considerably little scholarly attention given to ethical fundraising. Inspired by the aforementioned reasons, this study follows the stream of knowledge production literature that provides a useful guide for both scholars and practitioners (Ma & Konrath, 2018). Despite the diverse array of approaches employed, nonprofit knowledge production studies have provided insights about nonprofit sector research themes and agendas by reviewing previously published studies (An et al., 2022; Ma & Konrath, 2018). This study reviews previous studies focusing on fundraising, communication, and ethics and attempts to answer the following research question: How ethical topics have been studied in fundraising communication?

We first discuss theories of ethical fundraising that are particularly related to communication, and then we move on to discussing the data and methods used to address the research topic, as well as reporting the study's findings in terms of the research trend that scholars have been studying in the field of fundraising communication over the last two decades, illustrating how ethics have been considered in fundraising communication research, and how fundraising communications have been conducted. Finally, the study's findings and their practical implications, as well as the study's limitations are discussed.

Fundraising ethics and communications

While scholars have utilized several theories and approaches to study fundraising ethics, this study focuses on two perspectives—namely, the normative and accountability perspectives—and

discusses how communications have been considered in these perspectives. Normative perspectives are well developed and generally considered as main approaches when studying ethics (MacQuillin, 2022). Accountability perspectives, on the other hand, have been widely used to discuss nonprofit organizations' responsibilities and obligations toward their stakeholders. Practitioners also use accountability concepts for fundraising ethics. For instance, AFP includes transparency and responsibility in their principles for ethical fundraising (Association of Fundraising Professionals [AFP], 2019; Barrett, 2001).

Normative perspectives

Recently, MacQuillin (2022) comprehensively reviewed normative ethical theories/lenses of fundraising, using three major approaches (consequentialism, deontology, and virtue ethics). Among several normative theories, this study discusses three theories that may entail direct communications with core stakeholders: the public, donors, and beneficiaries. The first ethical theory/lens is "Trustism." Positioning public trust as its primary duty, this theory posits that fundraising is ethical "when it promotes, sustains, protects, and maintains public/donor trust in fundraising, and unethical when it damages or harms this trust" (MacQuillin, 2022, p. 6). This ethical lens is in congruence with earlier research. Anderson (1996) argued that fundraisers should build "enduring, trustworthy relationships with donors" (p. 75), and Rosen (2005) further discussed how maintaining and communicating ethical standards to their donors can enhance trust. From the Trustism lens, fundraising communication is unethical when it "damages or harms the public/donor trust." Trust derived from ethical communication leads to donors' favorable behavior, thus enabling nonprofits to retain existing donors, recruit prospective donors (Cho et al., 2019) and lurkers (Hong & Li, 2020), as well as reactivate lapsed donors (Feng, 2014). Existing research provides evidence that trust is positively associated with charitable giving (Chapman et al., 2021; Sargeant & Lee, 2002).

The second ethical theory/lens is "Donorcentrism." This lens is concerned with donor interests, and stipulates that fundraising is ethical "when it gives priority to the donor's wants, needs, desires and wishes" (MacQuillin, 2022, p. 7). According to this theory, fundraising communication becomes unethical when it ignores what donors want. For instance, it is ethical when donors receive authentic stories and information without playing emotions (De Bock & Faseur, 2017; Dean & Wood, 2017). As scholars argue, communication is fundamental to cultivating relationships with donors (Feng, 2014; Rosen, 2005) and these relationships are vital to the sustainability of the nonprofit sector (Waters, 2011). Nonprofit organizations concentrate their communication efforts on developing and maintaining positive relationships with donors. Part of the reason for this interest stems from the difficulty of attracting new donors, as acquiring a new donor is three to five times more expensive than maintaining an existing one (Feng, 2014).

Considering that fundraising practices mainly contact donors, beneficiaries can be easily forgotten. MacQuillin and Sargeant argue that "[n]one of the [normative] theories developed during the 1990s specifies that fundraisers owe any specific or particular duty to their organization's beneficiaries or service users" (MacQuillin & Sargeant, 2019, p. 246). According to the last theory, "Rights-balancing fundraising ethic theory," fundraising is ethical "when it balances the duty of fundraisers to ask for support, with the relevant rights of donors, such that a mutually beneficial outcome is achieved and neither stakeholder is significantly harmed" (MacQuillin, 2022, p. 10). Indeed, since beneficiaries cannot advocate for themselves, fundraisers have duties to their beneficiaries similar to doctors or lawyers (Breeze, 2017; Koshy, 2019). Therefore, it is critical for fundraisers to fully understand the rights of beneficiaries and service users. The question is how and by what means the fundraisers can learn about beneficiary rights.

Accountability perspectives

Ethical fundraising places great emphasis on the accountability of nonprofit organizations to be transparent and answerable for their actions, decisions, and the appropriate utilization of funds they raise (Connolly & Hyndman, 2013). This commitment demonstrates nonprofits' dedication to ethical practices, reassuring donors that their contributions are utilized appropriately (Dhanani & Connolly, 2015). Accountability in the nonprofit sector has been examined through various theoretical perspectives, such as principal-agent theory, stakeholder theory, and legitimacy theory (Dhanani & Connolly, 2012). Nonprofit accountability encompasses both external and internal dimensions. While traditionally seen as externally motivated, with agents being held accountable by principals, accountability is now understood as a felt responsibility driven by a sense of obligation (Dhanani & Connolly, 2015). Stakeholder theory (Freeman, 1984, 2010), provides a broader perspective on nonprofit accountability, emphasizing the need to account to all constituents, including donors, funders, regulators, and beneficiaries.

Nonprofit organizations engage with stakeholders to establish legitimacy, build reputation, and gain support, by deploying accountability mechanisms that align with stakeholder expectations (Connolly & Hyndman, 2013). Legitimacy is crucial for nonprofits as they rely on funding to sustain operations and support communities in need. Nonprofits, characterized as financially dependent entities driven by values, strive for legitimacy to ensure their survival (Benjamin, 2013; Benjamin et al., 2023; Ebrahim, 2005). In this sense, accountability serves as a vital tool for nonprofits to establish and maintain legitimacy by reporting on financial and social performance (Benjamin et al., 2023; Edwards & Hulme, 1996; Leardini et al., 2019; Lister, 2003).

A significant body of research highlights donors as the primary stakeholder group for accountability (Connolly et al., 2009; Connolly & Hyndman, 2013; Dhanani & Connolly, 2012). Donors rely on external communication channels for information since they are not directly involved in the nonprofit's management. Maintaining accountability to donors is essential for ensuring financial sustainability, as any lapses in donor accountability can have adverse effects on charitable contributions (Connolly et al., 2009; Connolly & Hyndman, 2013; Dhanani & Connolly, 2012, 2015). On the other hand, the concept of downward accountability focuses on facilitating progress towards a more just and democratic society by transferring the right of accountability to all those affected by the organization's activities (Christensen & Ebrahim, 2006; Dhanani & Connolly, 2015; Wellens & Jegers, 2014).

Dhanani and Connolly (2012) identified four main aspects of accountability that non-profit organizations should report on—namely, strategic accountability, fiduciary accountability, procedural accountability, and financial accountability. Strategic accountability involves disclosing organizational intentions, actions taken to fulfill those intentions, and measuring the results and impact of those actions in relation to the organization's vision and mission. Fiduciary accountability emphasizes integrity, compliance, good governance, as well as the protection of funds and assets. Procedural accountability relates to internal organizational operations and demonstrates alignment with societal norms and values. Financial accountability focuses on disclosing the organization's financial position, operational continuity, stability, viability, efficiency, and ensuring the proper handling of funds with care and transparency. This involves maintaining accurate financial records, conducting regular audits, and providing detailed financial reports to align with donors' expectations. Nonprofits must ensure that funds raised are utilized for their intended purpose. As such, financial accountability is a fundamental pillar of ethical fundraising communication (Connolly & Hyndman, 2013; Dhanani & Connolly, 2012; Gray et al., 2006). These four aspects of accountability ensure that nonprofits are accountable to various stakeholders, acting in the best interest of the public good.

Fundraising communications

As communication is essential for fundraising activity, nonprofit organizations develop their own strategies for fundraising communication and utilize a variety of messages and media. Effective fundraising communication plays a crucial role in establishing and maintaining trust with donors and other stakeholders. It demonstrates responsible operations and involves transparent information exchange both internally and externally, including accurate financial records, donation tracking, and regular updates on fund utilization (Hong & Li, 2020; Strickland & Vaughan, 2008; Suh et al., 2021). These reports are considered reliable and authentic sources of information, often required by law in Western economies, and fulfill management's reporting responsibilities (Connolly & Hyndman, 2013; Gray et al., 2006). Adequate accounting and reporting practices are further emphasized in the nonprofit sector to prevent scandals, maintain confidence, and promote a more accountable and legitimate sector (Connolly & Dhanani, 2009; Connolly & Hyndman, 2013). Communication also entails conveying the organization's mission, sharing impact stories, addressing concerns, and expressing appreciation for donors' support, thus fostering a strong relationship and trust (Connolly & Hyndman, 2013; Dhanani & Connolly, 2015).

Communication channels, such as annual reviews and web-based platforms, facilitate meaningful connections with donors and enhance accountability. Scholars highlight the importance of improved communication channels in effectively conveying stories, outputs, and impacts that align with donors' interests, fostering a meaningful connection with charities' work because donors often prioritize performance-related information over traditional financial statements (Benjamin et al., 2023; Connolly & Hyndman, 2013). Chu and Luke (2023) emphasize the significance of dialogue in enhancing the accountability of nonprofit organizations, particularly through web-based platforms that enable two-way interaction and stakeholder feedback.

Communication activities are conducted all the time, not just in fundraising activities. Research shows that donors are motivated when they see that their contributions are making a difference (Sargeant et al., 2008). Donors experience immaterial gratification when they learn how their charitable contributions aided the recipient. Therefore, it is critical to keep donors informed about the initiatives that they have supported. A concrete, trustworthy message may also improve the donors' perception of nonprofit's transparency. A concrete message enhances perceived transparency because it increases credibility by providing substantial information about how the raised funds will be used by the organization. Xiao, Huang, Bortree, and Waters (2021) found that a concrete message that details how a donation can be used to help a cause may be perceived as more credible and demonstrate the organization's effort to make the process more transparent, thus eliciting a higher donation intention and amount.

Despite the plethora of studies on fundraising communications that enhance trust and accountability, we can barely find studies that consider communications with or about the core stakeholder group, beneficiaries. It is understandable that the primary targets of communication in fundraising are donors. However, given that fundraisers encounter ethical dilemmas due to the tension between donor demands and beneficiary needs (MacQuillin & Sargeant, 2019), communications in fundraising should also consider both sides.

Data and method

Data collection

Step 1. Database and keywords selection

Inspired by previous studies (Jung et al., 2022; Moher et al., 2015; Xu & Huang, 2020), this study collected data from a bibliographic database, Web of Science, in October 2022. Web of Science[1] contains over 21,100 peer-reviewed journals including open access journals that

extensively cover academic fields. The database also contains all the major nonprofit-related journals that should be included in our dataset. We used a two-keyword combination method (Jung et al., 2022; Xu & Huang, 2020): (1) fundraising + communicat* and (2) fundraising + message*. We intentionally excluded the terminology "ethic*" to see how ethics-related research topics have been studied in fundraising communication. We also did not include other terminologies such as accountability, transparency, and trust because these terms have broad applicability across a diverse spectrum of research domains, which could potentially lead us to gather bibliographic records that bear no relevance to our research focus. Moreover, their inclusion might inadvertently limit the scope of our search. Our research aimed to cast a wide net when accumulating bibliographic resources.

Step 2. Searching and filtering articles

We only included journal articles and excluded books, book chapters, dissertations, theses, reports, conference proceedings, and unpublished articles. Journal articles meet a certain level of quality through a review process including peer-reviews, whereas others do not necessarily take the process (Barroso-Méndez et al., 2015). Only articles that were published in English and that contain selected keywords in any fields in the bibliographic record were retrieved. As described in Figure 1, a total of 372 articles were collected from the search. From the search of fundraising + communicat*, 292 journal articles were collected, and 80 journal articles were collected from the search of fundraising + message*. After removing duplicates, the final sample size for the articles was 327. These articles were used for the overall research trend analysis and word correlation analysis.

Step 3. Selecting a subset of studies for the narrative review

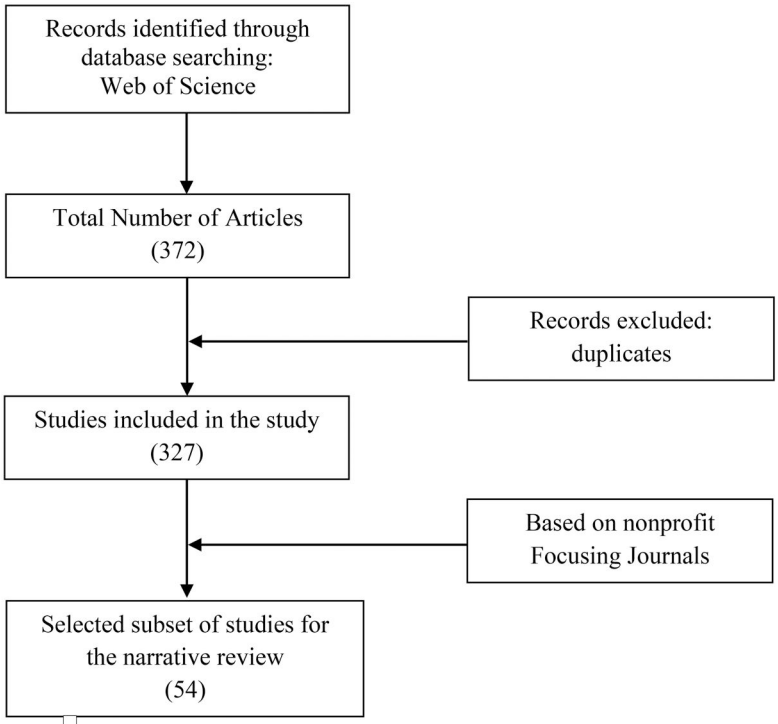
For the narrative review, we selected 54 articles from the final sample of 327 articles based on the eight journals whose focus is mainly the nonprofit sector: *Journal of Philanthropy and Marketing* (formal name: *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*), *Journal of Nonprofit and Public Sector Marketing*, *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly*, *Nonprofit Management and Leadership*, *Voluntas*, *International Review on Public and Nonprofit Marketing*, *Journal of Nonprofit Education and Leadership*, and *Journal of Public and Nonprofit Affairs*. As shown in Figure 1, 26 articles have been published in the *Journal of Philanthropy and Marketing* which makes up the largest share (48%) of the subset.

Analysis and findings

Descriptions of overall trends

Although there has been a great deal of work examining fundraising over the last few decades, the number of journal articles that we searched indicates that fundraising communication, particularly ethical fundraising communication, has been rarely studied by researchers. We identified 12 journal articles with the term ethic* in their title or abstract among the 327 studies (selected articles for this study). Additionally, only two articles include the term among 54 articles (subset of studies for the narrative review) that have been published in nonprofit-related journals. Notably, those articles were published since 2011 (Table 1). Our findings confirm the argument from a recently published article that "ethics of fundraising is a topic that has received scant attention from scholars and academics" (MacQuillin, 2022, p. 1).

Nonetheless, related research has been steadily increasing over time. Figure 2 shows an increase in the number of articles published by year. This number was insignificant until 2004, but it increased to 35 in 2021 and to 54 in 2022. Table 2 shows the top five keywords that appear



Journal name	Number of articles
Journal of Philanthropy and Marketing (formal name: International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing)	26
Journal of Nonprofit and Public Sector Marketing	8
Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly	8
Nonprofit Management and Leadership	6
International Review on Public and Nonprofit Marketing	3
Voluntas	1
Journal of Nonprofit Education and Leadership	1
Journal of Public and Nonprofit Affairs	1
8 Journals	**54**

Figure 1. Flow diagram for articles selection.

Table 1. Number of studies that include "ethic*" in either title or abstract.

Year	2011	2014	2015	2016	2018	2019	2020	2022	Total
Number of Studies	1	2	1	1	2	1	1	3	12

the most frequently in the titles and abstracts of published articles. Relatively, general keywords were found in 1990s and 2000s such as donor, relationship, interaction, charity, and information. On the other hand, more specific keywords were found in 2010s until 2022 including social media and crowdfunding, indicating that fundraising communication strategies have been diversified to include internet-based channels. Such results are consistent with the previous study, arguing that new media technologies have been increasingly studied in recent years (Jung et al., 2022).

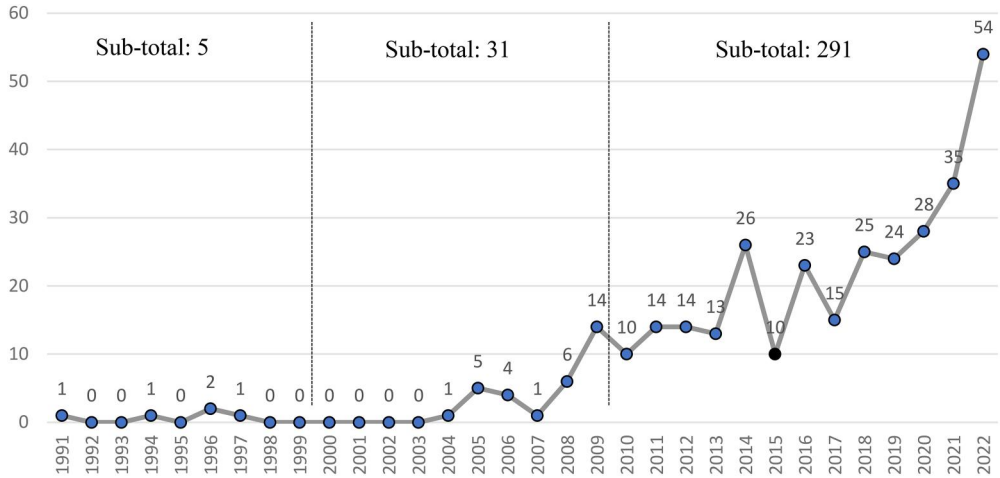


Figure 2. Number of article publications by year.

Table 2. Top five keywords from titles and abstracts.

1990s (1991 – 1999)		2000s (2000 – 2009)		2010s to 2022 (2010 – 2022)	
Title	Abstract	Title	Abstract	Title	Abstract
campaign	donor	relationship	donor	crowdfunding	social
	party	donor	relationship	social	crowdfunding
	information	charity	organization	media	media
	interaction	applying	public	giving	organization
	labeling	building	legacy	public	public

Note. Excluded keywords: (1) search keywords: fundraising, communicat*, ethic*, message*, (2) keywords that are commonly used in journal articles: research, paper, study, results.

Text network analysis: Word correlation

To identify how search terminologies link with each other, we conducted text network analysis using word correlation. The final dataset of 327 studies was used for this analysis. In this instance, two words occur together in the title or abstract of articles but do not necessarily appear consecutively (Jung et al., 2022; Silge & Robinson, 2017). Using the phi coefficient that is commonly used for binary correlation, word correlation indicates "how often [two words] appear together relative to how often they appear separately" (Silge & Robinson, 2017, p. 63). This approach provides an illustration of meaningful relationships between keywords. Before conducting a text network analysis, tokenized main keywords were unified. For instance, "communicate" was replaced with "communication" and "message" was replaced with "messages." As the next step, a word correlation analysis was performed using any two combinations of the three main keywords: fundraising, communication, and messages.

Several combined keywords were found to occur in titles and abstracts. Figures 3 and 4 show the word correlations from titles and abstracts and the thickness of each line presents the level of correlation. As shown in Figure 3, framing, effectiveness, consequences, charity, experimental, situational, exploring, and theory occur among the three main keywords in titles. We also found that the keyword "ethics" occurs only with "fundraising," but not with the others. On the other hand, Figure 4 describes that donation and findings are associated with both "fundraising" and "messages," while the term "ethics" does not appear, indicating that no significant keywords were associated with each other in abstracts. In short, the two figures indicate that the research on fundraising communication has paid little attention to ethical issues.

Since the term "ethic*" is hardly seen in the previous text network analysis, we conducted additional word correlation analyses using the specific term "ethic*." Figure 5 shows that

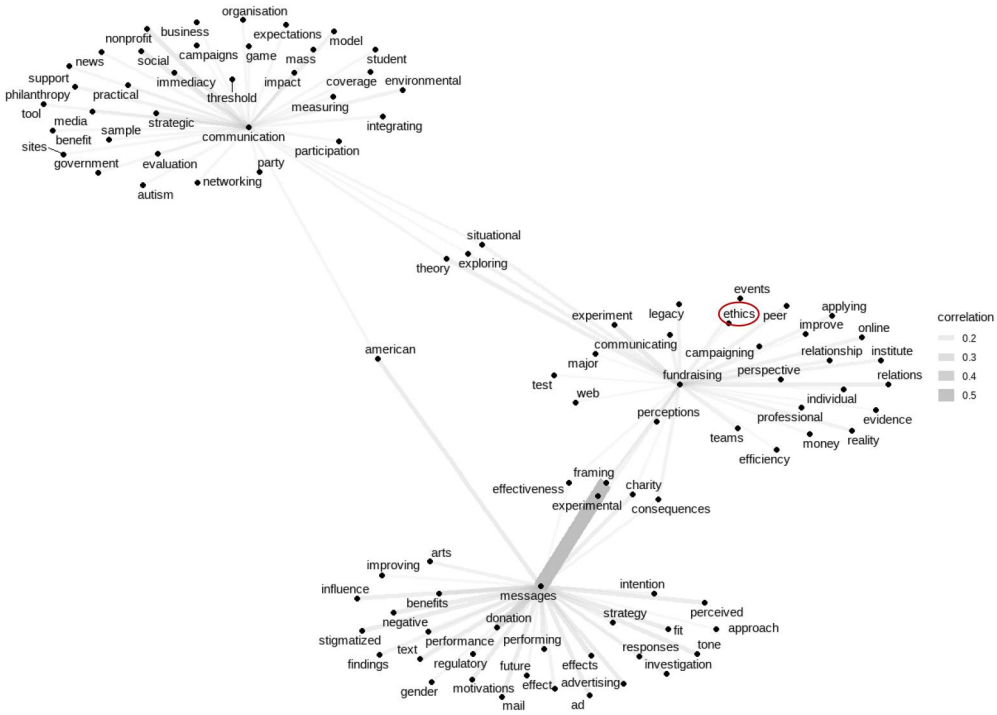


Figure 3. Word correlations: search terms from titles.

Figure 4. Word correlations: search terms from abstracts.

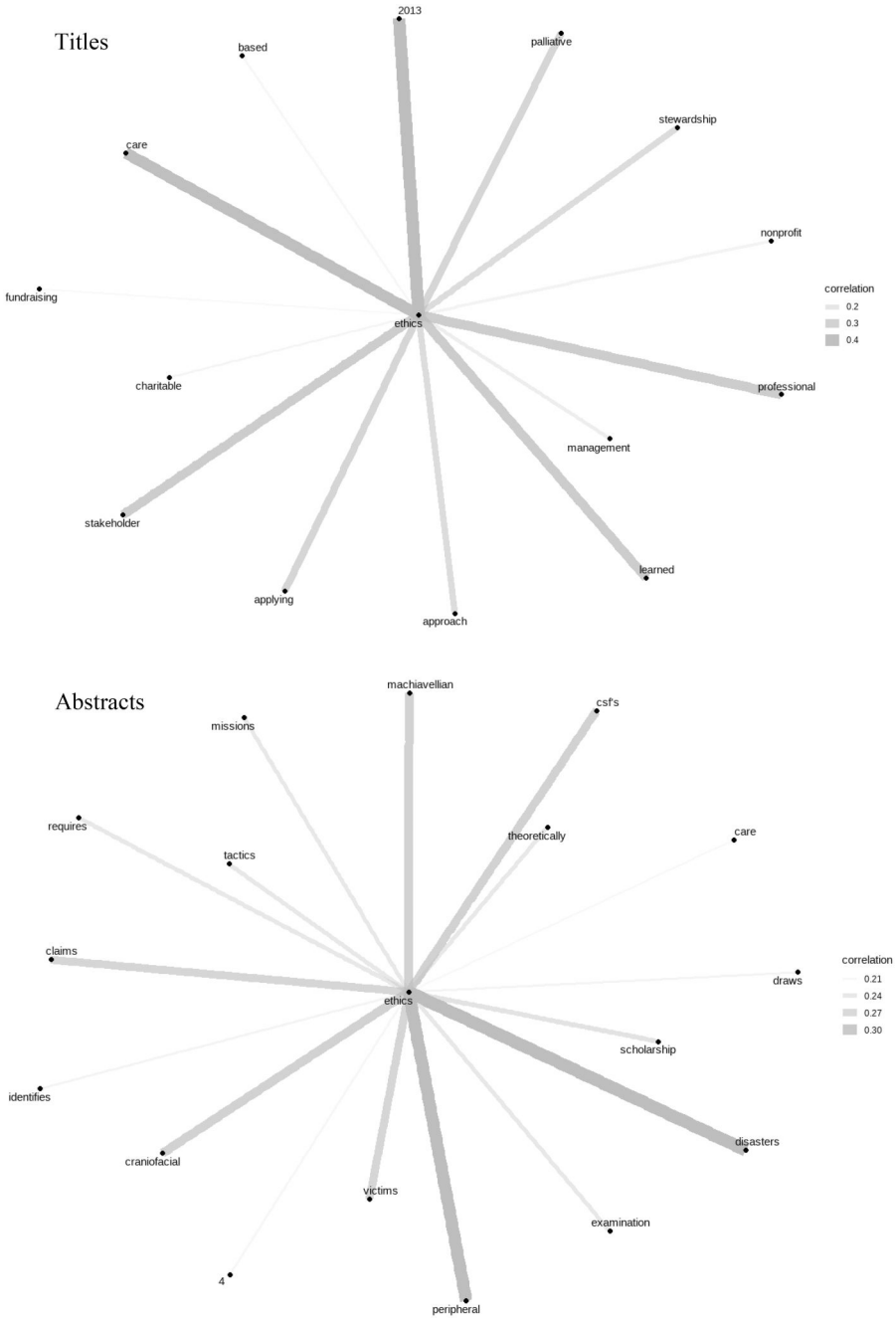


Figure 5. Word correlations with "ethic*" from titles and abstracts.

stewardship, stakeholder, professional, and care have been correlated in research titles. The keyword "stewardship" has been mainly used for building relationships with donors (Gardner & Rhodus, 2015; Waters, 2009b). One exception is the study by Madden, Harrison, and Vafeiadis (Madden et al., 2022), reviewing ethics of care orientation toward donors, employees, beneficiaries and volunteers. In research abstracts, missions, tactics, disasters, and victims have been used with "ethics." In particular, the keyword "victims" was used for depicting poverty in fundraising

campaigns (Thompson & Weaver, 2014), or describing someone experienced traumatic incidents (Chen et al., 2020) and disasters (Waters, 2009a). The results indicate that scholars use the term "ethics" with beneficiaries often in extreme contexts.

Narrative reviews: Data subset of 54 articles

By reviewing the subset of 54 articles, this section delves more deeply into the stakeholders who are involved, the messages that are delivered, and the media and channels that are used to convey fundraising messages.

Stakeholders

Fundraising activities require nonprofits to be engaged with diverse stakeholders, including different types of donors and beneficiaries. Within the subset of articles examined, a notable concentration of studies was observed pertaining to individual donors. In particular, a significant number of studies have paid special attention to individuals who pledge considerable amount of donations or stay with nonprofits for a longer term. A total of 11 articles have examined legacy (bequest giving) donors, major gift donors or annual giving donors. We also found that four articles have studied fundraisers, while none of the 54 articles in our review specifically centers on the beneficiaries who are recipients of nonprofit services.

Major gift donors. There is a wide variety of major gifts, including donations of considerable cash, valued assets, or in-kind gifts, such as priceless art or tangible personal property. Prospective major-gift contributors are often between the ages of 50 and 70, conservative in their political views, and well-educated (Wymer et al., 2006). A major-gift donor is also a successful entrepreneur, professional, or member of a wealthy family with financial expertise, as well as grown children who are financially secure and assets that worth at least 20 to 50 times greater than what the nonprofit organization is asking for (Knowles & Gomes, 2009). Scholars propose the AID-TIM (awareness and understanding, interest and involvement, desire to help, trial gift, information about what and how to give, and major gift action) model for major gift fundraising and "relationship fundraising" which is centered on cultivating personal connections with contributors (Drollinger, 2018; Knowles & Gomes, 2009).

Annual and longer-term donors. Maintaining annual and longer-term donors enables nonprofits to predict their revenues and plan their businesses accordingly because of their donation behavior (Li et al., 2020). As a basic and important strategy, nonprofits utilize various forms or channels that express their appreciation to these donors. Donors who gain "positive feelings towards the receipt of acknowledgements of donations" (Bennett, 2006, p. 62) are more likely to stay with the nonprofit longer. In this sense, donors are considered as partners, and thus showing the direct outcomes of the donation promotes further donations for a longer time. Commitment to charitable giving is fueled by a variety of factors, one of which is trust that is generated by being "open, honest, and consistent in all communications" (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007, p. 63).

Legacy donors. Many nonprofits have long relied heavily on charitable bequests and other planned endowments to sustain their operations. The goal of legacy fundraising is to persuade individuals to leave a philanthropic bequest to a certain organization (Wise, 2005; Wishart & James, 2020). Since endowments typically arrive years or decades later, legacy fundraisers face the challenge that pledged plans can be changed before receiving the actual gifts, making outcome measurement difficult (Wise, 2005). Therefore, managing legacy donations relies on cultivating

strong relationships with donors. Scholars recommend approaching the solicitation of legacy gifts from the elderly with sophistication (Cole et al., 2005; Sargeant & Hilton, 2005).

Lapsed donors. Scholars suggest that efforts for gaining back lapsed donors are worthwhile because they have already demonstrated their interests in the nonprofit's mission (Bennett, 2009). Also, lapsed donors already know the nonprofit's work, so the nonprofits would save money for making supplements to provide information about the nonprofits. Lapsed donors are more likely to resume donations when they are satisfied with a nonprofit's communication and feel regret for withdrawing support (Bennett, 2009; Sargeant & Hudson, 2008).

Beneficiaries and service users. The types of individuals who gain benefits differ depending on the nonprofit subfields. For instance, patients are service users in the hospitals, while families in need can be beneficiaries or clients for human service organizations or international NGOs. Within the realm of fundraising practice, beneficiaries are often consumed as materials for appealing donors (e.g., Hansen, 2020). Among the subset of 54 articles examined, we identified only two that incorporate beneficiaries into their studies. Applying stakeholder theory, Hansen (2022) asserts that the interests of beneficiaries are not always aligned with nonprofits. Additionally, their involvement in fundraising practices may not always yield positive responses. Hansen (2022) argues for the recognition of beneficiaries as primary stakeholders and emphasizes the importance of evaluating their interests through meaningful engagement. Madden and colleagues (2022) similarly underscore the significance of prioritizing beneficiaries' needs over the dominance of any particular stakeholder group.

Fundraisers. Although fundraisers play a critical role in fundraising practices, research on this specific occupation remains limited (Meisenbach et al., 2019). We found that four articles have investigated fundraisers, and three articles generally discussed how nonprofits recruit qualified fundraisers and what strategies fundraisers use when soliciting donations (Bennett, 2012; Humalisto & Moilanen, 2019; Jones & Daniel, 2018). One study stood out, as it hones in on fundraisers' experiences and their management of stigma (Meisenbach et al., 2019).

Contents and messages

The effectiveness of fundraising depends on what communication content nonprofit organizations choose to deliver because it helps build trust and accountability. Transparency, credibility, and concreteness of messages play a key role in building relationships with potential and existing donors (Xiao et al., 2021). Nonprofits utilize a mixture of content/messages as described below.

Rational approach: Information and facts. For making an informed-donation decision, individuals seek accurate information about the nonprofit organizations. This information includes, among other things, mission, history, board of directors, performance, and financial statements. Nonprofits typically provide this type of information on their official websites (Saxton & Guo, 2011) and sometimes mail (e.g., annual report) or email (e-newsletter) it to their donors. Fundraisers also use statistics and empirical evidence when soliciting donations, as these elements contribute to bolstering the credibility of nonprofits (Hansen, 2020).

Emotional approach: Storytelling. Research has found that stories are effective for fundraising (Hansen, 2020). Stories, including success stories and documentaries, delivered in different forms using photos, texts, and videos, enable nonprofits to build branding and identity, leading them to

be successful in their fundraising activities (Waters & Jones, 2011). In particular, nonprofits have increasingly used social media, as creating favorable images and videos by sharing stories through social media, which can be easier and faster (Hong & Li, 2020; Kim et al., 2022).

Personalized relationship building. Besides the content that nonprofits intentionally create, other types of messages are also used in fundraising activities. Fundraisers' communication skills are critical for building relationships with donors. Previous research has found that people are more likely to donate when they receive prompt and timely responses with courtesy, and less pressure (Sargeant & Hilton, 2005; Sargeant & Hudson, 2008). A personalized relationship beyond the solicitation process leads donors to continue to donate to and work with the same nonprofit organizations (Waters, 2011). Moreover, Active Empathic Listening (AEL) plays a key role in building such relationships (Drollinger, 2018).

Media and channel strategy

Nonprofit organizations have been using a variety of media and channels to raise voluntary funds. The strategies of media and channels can be organized into three main categories: interpersonal, owned media, and digital media strategies.

Interpersonal communication strategies, including face-to-face conversations, telephone calls, and door-to-door communications, are verbal communications in which information is exchanged in person, allowing fundraisers to provide all relevant verbal and nonverbal information and to adjust the conversation according to the donors' real-time feedback (Humalisto & Moilanen, 2019; Pinazo & Arahuete, 2020). Interpersonal communications are primarily used to manage relationships with major donors because donors would require substantive information before they decide whether to donate to a specific nonprofit or not (Drollinger, 2018). For convenience, telephone conversations are used in place of face-to-face conversations, especially when the parties are geographically separated (Li et al., 2020).

Owned media strategies are fundraising communications over which fundraisers have content and audience control, and are the recommended methods of communication for annual donors (Li et al., 2020). Commonly used owned media strategies include direct mail and special events. *Direct mail*, also known as fundraising appeal letters, is an important part of an organization's fundraising efforts, designed for a variety of purposes, including acquiring new donors, renewing existing donors, upgrading to a higher donation amount, and appealing for special projects (Hansen, 2020). Annual giving programs are said to use this strategy as their primary source of funding (Li et al., 2020). *Special events*, on the other hand, are social gatherings that bring people from the organization and the community together to raise awareness of a need, awareness of an organization, and support for a cause (Higgins & Hodgins, 2008).

Digital media strategies. In the past decade, nonprofits have experimented with a variety of digital media strategies, including emails, websites, social media platforms, and crowdfunding. *Emails* and *websites* are owned media over which fundraisers have full control, albeit digitally. Emails are used as a convenient strategy to follow up with annual donors, whereas websites are primarily used to disseminate information and raise awareness about the nonprofit's mission and activities. Unlike emails and websites, *social media platforms*, such as Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram, are shared digital media through which nonprofits not only provide information and raise awareness about their activities, but also engage with stakeholders (Bhati & McDonnell, 2020). Also, nonprofits have been using YouTube to educate and inform viewers about their organizational missions, programs, and the services they provide. Waters and Jones (2011) argue that using these various types of videos in organized communication campaigns enables

nonprofits to build on their identity and strengthen their relationships with external stakeholders. Scholars further found that crowdfunding can be a successful fundraising tool when messages and contents are well communicated (Kim et al., 2022).

Ethical issues

By reviewing the literature, this study found that most of the ethical issues that have been examined in fundraising communication are closely tied to fundraising messages and contents. Messages can be roughly classified into two categories: (1) positive or gain framing and (2) negative or loss framing. While positive framing emphasizes the effects of giving, negative framing focuses on "the consequences of not giving" (Hansen, 2020, p. 156). Ethical concerns may occur in both framings. While positive framing seems to be of no harm to anyone, fundraisers may feel guilty when they exaggerate the effects or minimize the drawbacks of giving. Also, using a negative or loss framing could evoke feelings of discomfort or guilt in donors who opt not to contribute (Xiao et al., 2021).

In addition, hard tactics such as revenge, manipulation (intentionally guiding or altering behavior by giving opaque information), and intimidation rhetoric might be effective especially in online crowdfunding; nevertheless, they may raise serious concerns about ethical communication due to ignoring the rights of donors and beneficiaries or violating these stakeholders' values (Calic et al., 2021; De Bock & Faseur, 2017; Dean & Wood, 2017; Independent Sector, 2015; Routley & Koshy, 2022). Using manipulated, tricky, or deceived information or news is not only unethical due to its authenticity issue but also risky for nonprofit organizations. Once revealed, it significantly decreases the level of donors' trust. Finally, it is worth noting that there are potential donors who are also vulnerable. Gregory (2014) argues that elderly people with increasing rates of Alzheimer's and dementia are particularly vulnerable when being targeted by sophisticated marketing tactics. Practitioners also have recognized potential problems and developed guidance, such as "Treating donors fairly: Responding to the needs of people in vulnerable circumstances" by Chartered Institute of Fundraising (2021).

Another critical issue of ethical communication in fundraising is the tendency of consuming someone's misery. Some examples include ice bucket challenge (for ALS [amyotrophic lateral sclerosis] patients), polar plunge fundraising (for 6-month-old baby with a cancer), human ice cream sundae (for Tsunami victims in 2004), and brave the shave campaign (for cancer patients) (Chen et al., 2020; Gies, 2021). Suffering stories and horrifying photographs have been used by nonprofits and humanitarian organizations for decades to gain public awareness, media attention, and donations (Chen et al., 2020; Fehrenbach & Rodogno, 2015). Such stories and photos trigger instant emotional responses fueled by feelings of sympathy and guilt. While it is not easy for fundraisers to resist this temptation of pragmatic efficiency, this strategy may cause problems (Fehrenbach & Rodogno, 2015). Images of extreme poverty, so called *pornography of poverty*, that are often used by international NGOs bring distorted images of the developing countries. Employing such a framing approach prevents people from understanding the root causes of the social problems and reinforces negative stereotypes of those in need (MacQuillin et al., 2022; Nathanson, 2013).

We acknowledge that there could be other ethical issues related to fundraising communications that were not included in our literature review. Some cases may not even be seen as unethical at glance. For instance, photos of children in a developing country might be uploaded to social media without consent and people easily consume such online contents. The existence of content may become unethical while the absence of content may also cause unethical issues. Such ethical issues may have been well recognized by practitioners and we urge scholars to delve into these unexplored topics.

Discussion

Aligned with the stream of literature on knowledge production, this study traces the evolution of fundraising communication research over the last three decades in an attempt to explore (un)ethical issues that have been addressed in nonprofit research. First, as is consistent with prior research, we confirm that fundraising ethics have received little consideration in previous research. Our analysis also reveals that in the 2010s, a new trend began to emerge, with a greater emphasis on ethical fundraising. This shift in research focus could be explained by the increased use of digital media in nonprofit fundraising. The results also demonstrate that, despite the steady increase in fundraising communication over the past decades, research on the ethics of fundraising communication remains scarce.

Second, our results indicate that the majority of studies predominantly concentrate on donors, while a comparatively limited number of studies examine other stakeholder groups, beneficiaries and fundraisers. These results are consistent with previous research on charitable giving. Chapman et al. (2022) found that the literature on charitable giving and fundraising has been excessively concentrated on donors while giving little attention to beneficiaries and fundraisers. They pointed out that the studies on fundraisers are underrepresented, despite their critical roles in fundraising activities. We further found that research has portrayed beneficiaries as victims in mostly extreme contexts. Some scholars argue that nonprofits should consider different needs and interests among various stakeholders in the practice of fundraising and suggest that beneficiaries are involved and communicated with the nonprofits (Hansen, 2022; Madden et al., 2022). There is a need to promote a greater understanding of how nonprofits communicate with their beneficiaries about fundraising and what specific contents should be discussed. Further, future research can delve into how such communication enhances the perception of accountability and trust of nonprofit organizations.

Further, our review found that scholars have studied ethical issues in fundraising communication mostly generated by various sorts of messages and contents, rather than the media or the channels via which those messages are communicated. However, as recently developed media and channels, such as VR and YouTube, can play a role as a catalyst by allowing messages and content to be even more exposed, nonprofit scholars should pay special attention to the clients or beneficiaries who are more vulnerable to and affected by fundraising communications. A pertinent inquiry put forth by Routley and Koshy (2022) is whether the utilization of provocative imagery and narratives ultimately strengthens or exacerbates public trust in the context of fundraising efforts. Additionally, recent studies have emphasized that transparent and comprehensive information, along with honesty, constitutes the foundation of effective fundraising communication (Bennett, 2017; Xiao et al., 2021). Therefore, further investigations are warranted to delve into how these factors contribute to the cultivation of accountability and trust within nonprofit organizations.

Our study emphasizes the centrality of communication to fundraising activities. Communication is the means by which nonprofits communicate their mission, market their programs, build donor trust, enhance accountability, and thus ensure the continuation of their programs. However, fundraising communications should be guided by ethical standards and principles; otherwise, they risk being unethical, which will severely harm the nonprofit's reputation and continuity. Thus, adhering to ethical standards in fundraising communication is central to nonprofit organizations because the success of an organization's mission depends, to a large extent, on public trust: the trust of donors, volunteers, and the community served (LeClair, 2019). Donors give to and volunteers work for these organizations because they trust them to carry out their missions, to be good stewards of their resources, and to uphold the highest ethical standards (MacQuillin & Sargeant, 2019; Rosen, 2005).

In short, ethical fundraising communication is fundamental to building public trust, which is required to nonprofit organizations to provide effective services, as well as to raise the funds needed to carry out their missions. Nonprofit organizations and the people who work for them

will be better positioned to work with the public if they establish a reputation for making consistently good ethical decisions (LeClair, 2019; Schultz, 2004). The success that this generates will breed even more trust, and thus a cycle of increasing trust and success will be initiated.

Limitations and directions for future research

Like other studies, this study has its own limitations. These limitations pertain particularly to the data and the methods used. Restricting the data to a single database may have resulted in the omission of several journals that publish relevant papers. However, since our search results include all the major nonprofit-related journals the results especially from the narrative review should be consistent. Likewise, limiting the search to two-word combination method could have resulted in missing out other trends or patterns in the relevant research. As such the results of the study should be interpreted with caution. Future research may counter these limitations by using multiple databases and different search methods or, even, systematic reviews.

Based on the findings, we suggest that more diverse research topics need to be studied in the future. First, future research needs to pay more attention to other stakeholders such as fundraisers (employees), board, and volunteers from ethical lens. A recent study by Meisenbach, Rick, and Brandhorst (2019) examined fundraisers' stigma of the profession and argued that strategies to manage stigmatizing messages associated with their occupation are important to tackle their high turnover. Second, protection of privacy has become one of the major issues with the continued emerging new media and technologies such as AI (Artificial intelligence), metaverse, and deepfakes. Future research might also consider the factors that drive unethical fundraising communications and the types/profiles of nonprofit organizations that are more likely to get involved in such activities. In addition, preventive strategies beyond codes of ethics and ethical principles and guidelines could be investigated with an emphasis on the role of ethical leadership and ethical environment in promoting ethical fundraising communications.

Note

1. https://clarivate.com/webofsciencegroup/solutions/web-of-science-core-collection/

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Appendix A. 54 articles in the nonprofit-related journals

Year	Journal	Title	Author(s)
2004	NVSQ	Nonprofit arts organizations: Do funding sources influence spending patterns?	Hughes, P and Luksetich, W
2005	JPM	Legacy fundraising: a practical guide to the basics	Wise, Patrick
2005	JPM	Pledger modelling: Help the Aged case study	Cole, Karen and Dingle, Rachel and Bhayani, Rajesh
2005	JPM	The final gift: targeting the potential charity legator	Sargeant, Adrian and Hilton, T.
2008	JPM	Donor retention: an exploratory study of door-to-door recruits	Sargeant, Adrian and Hudson, Jane
2008	JNPSM	The Grape Escape-A FUNdraising Bike Tour for the Multiple Sclerosis Society	Higgins, Joan and Hodgins, Ashley
2009	JPM	Community fundraising 2.0 - the future of fundraising in a networked society?	Miller, Bryan
2009	JPM	Integrating fundraising and campaigning	Lawson, Roger and Ruderham, Ruth
2009	JNPSM	Regret and Satisfaction as Determinants of Lapsed Donor Recommencement Decisions	Bennett, Roger
2009	JNPSM	The Importance of Understanding Donor Preference and Relationship Cultivation Strategies	Waters, Richard
2009	NVSQ	Communicating the Realities of Charity Costs An Institute of Fundraising Initiative	Sargeant, Adrian and Lee, Stephen and Jay, Elaine
2011	JPM	Developing planned giving at the Salvation Army Southern Territory	Sargeant, Adrian and Hudson, Jane
2011	JNPSM	Exploring the Impact of American News Coverage on Crisis Fundraising: Using Media Theory to Explicate a New Model of Fundraising Communication	Waters, Richard and Tindall, Natalie
2011	JNPSM	Using Video to Build an Organization's Identity and Brand: A Content Analysis of Nonprofit Organizations' YouTube Videos	Waters, Richard and Jones, Paul
2011	NVSQ	Increasing Fundraising Efficiency Through Evaluation: Applying Communication Theory to the Nonprofit Organization-Donor Relationship	Waters, Richard D.
2012	JPM	Redeveloping the research section of Meningitis UK's website - A case study report	Witt, Jana and Rowland, Kate and Wilkinson, Clare
2012	JPM	Selection of individuals to serve on major gift fundraising teams: a study of membership choice criteria	Bennett, Roger
2014	JPM	Best practices in noncommercial radio fundraising: a practitioner perspective	Bentley, Joshua M.
2014	JPM	Celebrity altruism: the good, the bad and the ugly in relationships with fundraising charities	Kelly, Sean and Morgan, Gareth and Coule, Tracey
2014	JPM	The ecology of internal workplace giving at Indiana University: a case study of faculty and staff campus campaign communications and fundraising	Shaker, Genevieve G. and Kienker, Brittany L. and Borden, Victor M. H.
2014	JNPSM	Getting Lapsed Donors Back: An Empirical Investigation of Relationship Management in the Post-Termination Stage	Feng, Shanfei
2015	JPM	Individual characteristics and the arousal of mixed emotions: consequences for the effectiveness of charity fundraising advertisements	Bennett, Roger
2015	NML	The Family Tribute in Charitable Bequest Giving: An Experimental Test of the Effect of Reminders on Giving Intentions	James, III, Russell N.
2016	JPM	Framing charitable appeals: the effect of message framing and perceived susceptibility to the negative consequences of inaction on donation intention	Cao, Xiaoxia
2016	JPM	We the living: the effects of living and deceased donor stories on charitable bequest giving intentions	James, III, Russell N. and Routley, Claire
2016	NVSQ	Communicating to Improve Health: Using Theory to Improve Fundraising for Health-Related Events	Zheng, Yue and McKeever, Brooke Weberling
2016	NVSQ	Recognition and Cross-Cultural Communications as Motivators for Charitable Giving: A Field Experiment	Mason, Dyana P.

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Year	Journal	Title	Author(s)
2016	Voluntas	Investigating Philanthropy Initiatives in Chinese Higher Education	Sung, Chiu-I
2017	JNPSM	Relevance of Fundraising Charities' Content-Marketing Objectives: Perceptions of Donors, Fundraisers, and Their Consultants	Bennett, Roger
2017	NML	Episodic Volunteering at a Religious Megaevent POPE FRANCIS'S VISIT TO PHILADELPHIA	Cnaan, Ram A. and Heist, H. Daniel and Storti, Melissa Heinlein
2018	IRPNM	How proof of previous donations influences compliance with a donation request: three field experiments	Jacob, Celine and Gueguen, Nicolas and Boulbry, Gaelle
2018	JNPSM	Using Active Empathetic Listening to Build Relationships With Major-Gift Donors	Drollinger, Tanya
2018	JNEL	A Method for Research and Practice Using a Developmentally Informed Interview to Increase Donor Engagement	Jones, Jennifer Amanda and Daniel, David L.
2018	NML	Nonprofit fundraising with virtual reality	Yoo, Seung-Chul and Drumwright, Minette
2019	JPM	Anticipating public expectations of humanitarian action-An ethnographic study of recruiting donors through face-to-face fundraising	Humalisto, Niko Heikki and Moilanen, Noora Elina
2019	JPM	Exploring the use of Facebook as a marketing and branding tool by hospital foundations	Bali, Suchita and Belanger, Charles H.
2019	JPM	Fundraising efficiency in Buddhist temples in Thailand: An application of the stochastic frontier analysis model	Phairoon, Natchanon and Pholphirul, Piriya
2019	IRPNM	Current students as university donors?: determinants in college students' intentions to donate and share information about university crowdfunding efforts	Cho, Moonhee and Lemon, Laura L. and Levenshus, Abbey B. and Childers, Courtney C.
2019	NML	Managing occupational identity threats and job turnover: How former and current fundraisers manage moments of stigmatized identities	Meisenbach, Rebecca J. and Rick, Jessica M. and Brandhorst, Jaclyn K.
2020	JPM	An exploratory study of stewardship for Chinese nonprofit organizations	Li, Peiyao and Men, Linjuan Rita and Yue, Cen April
2020	NVSQ	Success in an Online Giving Day: The Role of Social Media in Fundraising	Bhati, Abhishek and McDonnell, Diarmuid
2020	NML	Stories of strangers: Writing donor acquisition letters in the human services	Hansen, Ruth K.
2021	JPM	Fundraising through the F2F: When the smile implies a rejection of the interaction	Pinazo, Daniel and Arahuete, Lorena
2021	JPNA	Nonprofit External Communications: General Management, Public Relations, or Fundraising Tool?	Suh, Jiwon and Hoang, Trang and Hijal, Imane
2021	NVSQ	High-Capacity Donors' Preferences for Charitable Giving	Alston, Mackenzie and Eckel, Catherine and Meer, Jonathan and Zhan, Wei
2022	JPM	Leading and lagging indicators in fundraising management: A Canadian case study	Dougherty, Christopher N.
2022	JPM	The final outcome of charitable bequest gift intentions: Findings and implications for legacy fundraising	Wishart, Roewen and James, III, Russell N.
2022	JPM	Applying a stakeholder management approach to ethics in charitable fundraising	Hansen, Ruth K.
2022	JPM	Racialised representations of Black African poverty in INGO communications and implications for UK African diaspora: Reflections, lessons and recommendations	Ademolu, Edward
2022	JPM	Relational care in communication as the basis of nonprofit fundraising: Theorizing professional ethics based in stewardship and ethics of care	Madden, Stephanie and Harrison, Virginia and Vafeiadis, Michail
2022	JPM	Understanding social influence in Facebook fundraising: Relationship strength, immediacy of needs, and number of donations	Xue, Fei and Zhou, Lijie
2022	NVSQ	Designing Social Media Fundraising Messages: An Experimental Approach to Understanding How Message Concreteness and Framing Influence Donation Intentions	Xiao, Anli and Huang, Yan and Bortree, Denise S. and Waters, Richard D.

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Year	Journal	Title	Author(s)
2022	NML	What convinces donors? An analysis of donation-based crowdfunding projects from nonprofit charities: The case of South Korea	Kim, Soobin and Kang, Chulhee and Engel, Rafael
2022	IRPNM	Elements that compose the non-profit BRAND orientation in an emerging country	Sepulcri, Lara Mendes Christ Bonella and Mainardes, Emerson Wagner

Note. Journal of Philanthropy and Marketing (JPM) = International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing, Journal of Nonprofit and Public Sector Marketing (JNPSM), Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly (NVSQ), Nonprofit Management and Leadership (NML), International Review on Public and Nonprofit Marketing (IRPNM), Journal of Nonprofit Education and Leadership (JNEL), Journal of Public and Nonprofit Affairs (JPNA).